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Plural marriage among the Wolof in the Gambia

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CHAPTER I THE PHYSICAL AND SOCIAL SETTING OF POLYGYNY

All grandchildren are referred to as set. There is a joking relationship between grandfathers and grandsons. A grandson is permitted to act disrespectfully toward his grandfather, pulling his beard, calling him by a nickname, making fun of his physique, and contradicting him. Grandparents rarely punish their grandchildren, either physically or verbally, and it is commonly accepted that grandparents tend to "spoil" their grandchildren.

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The immediate polygynous family consisting of a man, his wives, and their children cannot be disassociated from the social and economic life of the compound, or groupings of compounds, that make up the extended family. But for the purposes of this study attention will be focused on the polygynous family, with the larger social setting kept in mind and mentioned when it seems most relevant.

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Mohammedan law forbids a man to have more than four freeborn wives. However, he is permitted to have as many jam wives (tara) as he can afford. The designation for the first wife in a polygynous family is awo; the latest wife is called t[unknown]pa. The other wives are referred to by their names.

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The following figures on plural marriage among the Wolof in Upper and Lower Saloum are in accord with the general West  36 African pattern in respect to the average number of wives per adult male.²⁶ Thus, in the village of Njau, the

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28 men of marriageable age had 1.35 wives on the average,²⁷ the distribution being as follows:

²⁶ Daryll Forde found a mean number of 1.7 wives among 121 married men of all ages. See his Marriage and the Family among the Yako, London, 1941, p. 79.

²⁷ In Njau, of the 28 men of marriageable age, 17 belong to the jam class which would appear to account for the relatively lower number of wives per man.

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